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Domestic Influences on the Nationalist Revival in France, 1909-1914

David E. Sumler

Historians have assumed that prior to World War I increasing international tensions dominated the thoughts and actions of European politicians to such an extent that they viewed domestic politics as of secondary importance. In the case of France the election of the revanchist Raymond Poincaré to the presidency of the Republic in January 1913 and the passage of the Three Years Law the following July have been attributed primarily to a "nationalist revival" occasioned by Germany's bellicose foreign policy.¹ Little attention has been paid to the fact that domestic political battles continued from the Separation to the outbreak of the war, and they became increasingly heated until French society, on the eve of the war, was severely polarized. In this context the nationalist revival appears to have been less a reaction to German pressure than an integral part of a conservative resurgence, a product of the domestic struggle for power between the center-right and center-left.

From 1900 to 1914 France, in common with the other great powers, experienced a rapid growth of the political left. After the Dreyfus Affair the Radical party had become the dominant party in the National Assembly and, with the cooperation of the anticlerical moderates and of socialists, had enacted the Separation. In the legislative election of 1906 the electorate endorsed both the Radical party and the policy of separation. Radicals and Radical-Socialists, controlling 247 votes out of 597 in the Chamber of Deputies, dominated the new legislature. The centrist position of the Radicals made it impossible to form a

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¹ Eugen Weber, *The Nationalist Revival in France* (Berkeley, 1959), pp. 9, 11, 43, 100, presents this interpretation.

government without sizable Radical support. Under the premiership of Georges Clemenceau the Radical-dominated Chamber enacted a series of reforms that alienated the anticlerical moderates who had supported the Separation but would not support social measures. Above all, these moderates were thoroughly alarmed when Clemenceau's Minister of Finance, Joseph Caillaux, proposed the enactment of a graduated income tax. To prevent such reforms the moderates began to cooperate with traditional, clerical conservatives and to lay the parliamentary basis for a conservative resurgence.

Aristide Briand, Clemenceau's successor as premier, provided the focus of this incipient coalition. Traditionally, the French premier delivers a major address to the nation each fall, just prior to the opening of the legislative session. Often these speeches are given merely to serve tradition. This was not true of Briand's speech given at Périgueux on October 10, 1909. To the contrary, in this speech Briand called for a new era in French politics. The time had come, he said, to heal the wounds caused by the bitter struggle over the Separation. ". . . We are at an hour when the country feels a great, an irresistible need for union, concord and brotherhood . . . ; it is necessary to end the hatred and fratricidal struggles among [France's] children. . . . We wish to give to all, without distinction of party, . . . justice . . . and the freedom to express their opinion. . . ." ² This was a repudiation of the record of the Radical party. Briand implied that, in their nine years of dominance, the Radicals had nurtured strife among Frenchmen, had governed not for the nation but for their narrow constituencies, and had denied their opponents freedom of speech and justice in the courts. He then went on to warn that, by their insistence on such reforms as a state monopoly of education and a graduated income tax, the Radicals were threatening to prolong the divisions within the country.

With the intention of ending Radical dominance of the Chamber of Deputies, Briand became the first premier to endorse an electoral reform based on proportional representation. Under *représentation proportionnelle* (RP in the contemporary press) all parties would receive seats in the chamber in proportion to the percentage of the popular vote which they received on a single ballot.³ Politicians of both left

² *Le Bulletin de l'Alliance républicaine démocratique* (hereafter referred to as *Le Bulletin ARD*), April 3, 1910. Briand's speech was reprinted "on the demand of the Democratic Alliance's candidates" during the election campaign of 1910.

³ For the effect of the proportional system on parliamentary representation cf. Peter Campbell, *French Electoral Systems and Elections, 1789-1957* (London, 1958), pp. 86-95.

and right attributed the Radicals' electoral success to the existing two-ballot, single-member constituency system. On the first ballot electors voted according to ideological preference, but on the second ballot conservatives voted Radical to prevent the election of socialists; just as socialists voted Radical on the second ballot to prevent a conservative victory.

By endorsing *RP* Briand had begun a parliamentary struggle which was to last for three years. One should not suppose that the debate was prolonged merely by the electoral fears of legislators. The motivating force of the campaign for *RP* was the desire to weaken the Radical party.⁴ Writing after the Radical landslide of 1906 Jacques Mars revealed the conservatives' fears about the *scrutin d'arrondissement*:

A third fact to note is that in certain departments of France the opposition is being reduced to the state of an irretrievable minority . . . in spite of the relative strength of the opposition forces. . . .

These departments [Ain, Ardennes, Charente-Inférieure] elected no candidates of *Action libérale* or of the *Fédération républicaine progressiste*. Yet, the liberal and progressist forces equal a quarter [of the voters] . . . in Ain; more than a third . . . in Ardennes; more than a third . . . in Charente-Inférieure.⁵

The Radicals were just as aware of the implications of proportional representation. At an antiproportionalist rally in December 1909 the president of the executive committee of the Radical party spoke bluntly about the blessings of the single-member constituency: "I know what the constituency system has given us; I know that at each election our party ranks have swelled; I know that the majority system with a limited suffrage—perhaps too limited—has produced a Radical and Radical-Socialist majority even in the Senate. . . ."⁶

Enactment of an electoral reform based on proportional representation was to be the instrument for achieving Briand's goal of reduced domestic tension. This more general policy of conciliation became known as *apaisement*, which in 1909 referred to healing the

⁴ The national campaign for *RP* seems to have begun with the founding of the pamphlet-sized *Le Proportionniste*, July 1905, in Lille. Eugène Duthoit, a professor at the University of Lille, was the editor. The Comité républicain de la représentation proportionnelle held its first rally March 2, 1907.

⁵ "Les Elections des 6-20 mai 1906," *Le Proportionniste*, V (July 1, 1906), 5.

⁶ Comité parlementaire de défense contre la proportionnelle, *Les Dangers de la proportionnelle. Discours prononcés au Banquet d'Union républicaine du lundi 20 décembre 1909* . . . (Auxerre, 1909), p. 35.

wounds inflicted by the Separation controversy. Together *apaisement* and *RP* offered the moderate conservatives of the Alliance républicaine démocratique (ARD) and the Fédération républicaine (FR) a practical anti-Radical program. From 1911 to 1914 this program became the focal point of French politics. Each ministry "either revived the idea of *apaisement* and national unity or, conversely, manifested a belief in the desirability of party strife."⁷

Two years of political equivocation elapsed between Briand's first formulation of these ideas and the appointment of Raymond Poincaré as premier, which signaled the success of Briand's policies. Running on basically anti-Radical programs in the legislative election of April 1910, both the center-right and the Socialist party made gains at the Radicals' expense. Three brief ministries followed in eighteen months. Briand remained in power by courting the conservatives until February 1911.⁸ After Briand's fall the Radicals formed a loose coalition with the Socialists to support the next two ministries—those of Ernest Monis and Joseph Caillaux. Neither of these men could weld his majority into a stable alliance. Radicals and Socialists cooperated in May 1911 when Monis attacked railroad owners for mistreatment of their employees and again when he asked for a complete state monopoly of education. The leftist coalition also united behind Caillaux's insistence upon a graduated income tax. The main issue of debate in 1911, however, was none of these; it was electoral reform based on proportional representation. On this the Socialists split with the Radicals and voted with the conservatives for the reform. As long as *RP* remained the central political issue, no true left-right division of the Chamber was possible. For a stable, coherent majority to be formed, either *RP* had to be eliminated as an issue or another more important issue had to arise which would unite the Socialists and Radicals in spite of *RP*.

Both of these conditions were fulfilled under the Poincaré ministry, in office from January 1912 to January 1913. During these twelve months Poincaré, a senator from Lorraine identified with the moderate ARD, passed an electoral reform bill and initiated a policy of *fierté nationale*. Historians have assumed that Poincaré was swept into office

⁷ Malcolm Anderson, "The Right and the Social Question in Parliament, 1905-1919," in David Shapiro, ed., *The Right in France, 1890-1919* (London, 1962), p. 123.

⁸ Briand courted the conservatives most openly when he used the regular army to break a railroad strike in October 1910. His justification was that the railroads were necessary to national defense. See Raoul Persil, *Alexandre Millerand* (Paris, 1949), p. 69, *Le Temps*, Oct. 14-15, 1910, and *La Croix*, Oct. 15-20, 1910.

by a tide of nationalist fervor resulting from the Agadir incident of July 1911.⁹ A close study of the origins of his ministry suggests that this was not the case and that domestic politics played at least as large a rôle as foreign affairs in the events of December–January 1911–12.

Caillaux, who preceded Poincaré, was a Radical and an ardent champion of the income tax. He presented his cabinet to the Chamber of Deputies on July 1, 1911. On the same day a German gunboat steamed into the Moroccan port of Agadir. Morocco had long been a source of friction between France and Germany, and, on this occasion, the Germans were protesting French military movements there. Although Agadir caused a flurry of alarm in French newspapers for several days, the incident was overshadowed while the Chamber remained in session by the debate over *RP*. There was no immediate patriotic response from the press as certain nationalists later claimed.¹⁰ During the legislative recess, newspapers carried almost daily accounts of diplomatic developments, but only rarely were editorials devoted to Franco-German relations.¹¹ For the most part the press reflected official optimism. After each short-lived crisis—as in mid-September when Caillaux required conscripts eligible for discharge to remain in active service—the press would return to domestic politics.

During October and November the conservative press was greatly disturbed by Caillaux's plans for the fall legislative session. In a speech at Saint-Calais on November 5 Caillaux renewed his call for an income tax, renounced the idea of national union as "chimerical and dangerous," and omitted any reference to electoral reform.¹² On October 21 the moderate *Le Temps* warned its readers that Caillaux's minister of finance, J. J. Klotz, had begun a surreptitious campaign to get the Senate's budget commission to act on the income tax bill. Finally, in

⁹ See, for example, Weber, *Nationalist Revival*, p. 100; Jacques Chastenet, *Jours inquiets et jours sanglants* (Paris, 1957), p. 96; Gordon Wright, *Raymond Poincaré and the French Presidency* (Stanford, 1942), p. 25. Cf. n.18 below.

¹⁰ See the editorial "L'Affaire qui unit," *Le Temps*, Sept. 17, 1911. The title was taken from a speech by Paul Deschanel, a moderate who was elected president of the Chamber of Deputies with conservative support in May 1912.

¹¹ Newspapers examined for the period July 1, 1911, to Dec. 31, 1911, were: Paris—*L'Intransigeant*, *La Lanterne*, *Le Matin*, *Le Temps*; Beauvais—*Le Moniteur de l'Oise*, *La République de l'Oise*; Lille—*La Dépêche du Nord*; Montpellier—*L'Eclair du Midi*, *Le Petit Meridional*. These papers, selected for regional and political variety, are also related to a larger study of which this article is only a part. The chronological development of journalistic opinion is also presented in Weber, *Nationalist Revival*, p. 96, and E. Malcolm Carroll, *French Public Opinion and Foreign Policy, 1870–1914* (New York, 1931), pp. 241–47.

¹² *Le Matin* and *Le Temps*, Nov. 6, 1911. See Georges Bonnefous, *Histoire politique de la Troisième République* (Paris, 1956), I, 250–51.

mid-November, Caillaux made a move that shocked the business community. The Bank of France had been in need of credit and had requested the government to modify the regulations governing the Bank's reserves. Caillaux agreed to do this only if the Bank would grant its employees a *statut* or code governing working conditions, pensions, and promotions. Though the Bank accepted, *Le Temps* fulminated against this act as *intervention à outrance* in private business.¹³ At the annual meeting of the presidents of the chambers of commerce of France held in Paris on November 23, French businessmen condemned Caillaux for "this innovation which gives the Minister of Finance the right to interfere in the management of a private commercial establishment."¹⁴

The newspapers once again turned their attention to Franco-German relations when in December the chamber began to debate the ratification of the treaty Caillaux had negotiated with the Germans. In spite of dissatisfaction with the manner in which the negotiations had been conducted by Caillaux the Chamber ratified the treaty 393 to 36, with 140 abstentions. Still, the agreement lacked the Senate's approval. As the year 1912 began, rumors circulated that the Senate would overthrow the ministry rather than ratify the treaty, and various conservative newspapers reported a senatorial plot to topple Caillaux.¹⁵ On January 9 Clemenceau, in the senatorial commission investigating the treaty, accused Caillaux of having acted illegally by conducting personal negotiations without informing the ministry of foreign affairs. Caillaux's foreign minister refused to defend his chief and resigned. Since no one would accept the vacant post, Caillaux was forced to resign the next day.

The commentary on this crisis in the moderate press does not support the interpretation which holds that Caillaux was toppled because of his foreign policy. *Le Bulletin ARD* pointed explicitly to Caillaux's political error: "The mistake of the *Président du conseil* was to base his Ministry too openly and too exclusively on the Radical-Socialist Party. . . ." The ARD had supported him "to the day when he gave his approval to projects of a collectivist nature, both hostile toward us and disrespectful of contracts."¹⁶ There can be no doubt that *Le Bulletin ARD* saw Caillaux's faults completely in domestic

¹³ *Le Temps*, Nov. 17, 1911.

¹⁴ *Le Temps*, Nov. 23, 1911.

¹⁵ *La République française*, Jan. 1, 1912; *L'Intransigeant*, Jan. 9, 1912.

¹⁶ Jan. 31, 1912.

terms. Three weeks after the event another paper, *L'Intransigeant*, commented: "We wager that today no one cares about the treaty, which was only a *machine de guerre* against the government. The comedy unrolled, in fact, in a premeditated way. The passion of certain journals and of certain parliamentarians has calmed as if by magic."¹⁷

The ministry that Poincaré formed was a cabinet of luminaries, a cabinet of "national union" which took all its members from the center of the political spectrum. It included Briand, Alexandre Millerand, Théophile Delcassé, Léon Bourgeois, and Jean Dupuy. Historians have argued that this ministry represented an irresistible tide of nationalism loosed by the Agadir crisis. For instance, Eugen Weber has written: "As ever in times of foreign danger, national union had been sought and found round a moderate Republican."¹⁸ Yet, no one has suggested that there was any organized movement to further Poincaré's chances to become premier either before or after Caillaux's fall. In fact, President Fallières had first asked Léon Bourgeois and then Delcassé to form a cabinet before turning to Poincaré. The overture to Bourgeois was ritual. Delcassé, however, the obvious choice to form an anti-German cabinet, was not able to gain support.¹⁹ Poincaré was probably a popular compromise.²⁰ He was not pushed forward by a surge of public sentiment or by a chauvinistic clique in parliament.

To the contrary, it was Poincaré who hoped to create a nationalist revival among his countrymen. Several days after Agadir Poincaré gave a speech before the ARD in which he called for a "national renaissance." Since the language he used was typical of conservative orators, there is no reason to think the speech was written in response to Agadir. But Poincaré added a new urgency to the old slogans:

We should undertake a crusade in this troubled and disoriented country—to remind it that a great nation has reasons for its existence other than material interests; to re-awaken wherever they have languished, individual energies. . . .

¹⁷ Jan. 31, 1912.

¹⁸ *Nationalist Revival*, p. 100. Other historians with similar views include Jacques Chastenot: "In brief, [Poincaré] was carried, more so outside of Parliament than in it, by the tide of public opinion" (*Jours inquiet*, p. 96), and Gordon Wright: "The people of France, their patriotism ruffled, were in a mood for a new premier who would speak fearlessly and would present something more than a political clique" (*Raymond Poincaré*, p. 25).

¹⁹ Bonnefous, *Histoire politique*, p. 273.

²⁰ Raymond Poincaré, *Au service de la France* (Paris, 1926), I, 12-13.

Those who speak slanderously of French decadence . . . are those who believe the temporary troubles and depressive moments are permanent. . . . The malaise of which we are the troubled observers is nothing compared to the storms of the past.²¹

Poincaré then spoke of civil disorder, the need for a strong government, the prevalence of political demagoguery, and his opposition to an income tax. Poincaré's only reference to foreign affairs was a call for a foreign policy free from domestic politics.

Judging from this speech one might expect, then, that Poincaré would use the occasion of the presentation of his ministry to the chamber to call for a nationalist revival. Without going so far he did call for national unity. He said in opening that he had felt it his duty "to group, in a national spirit, all the factions of the republican party" and that in doing this he only reflected the nation's mood.²² Poincaré then promised to sponsor the ratifications of the Franco-German treaty. In doing this he even praised the treaty, making the change of ministries seem pointless. When he spoke of domestic affairs, however, the distinction between himself and Caillaux was evident. "[A] great republican democracy . . . must know, above all, how to discipline itself. . . . The maintenance of public order, the unbending repression of crimes and offences against persons and property, and the regular functioning of the great administrative services are the elementary duties of all government. But the power which the people delegate to the men who direct their affairs . . . means nothing, if it does not contain . . . a mission of social direction and education."²³ On the vote of confidence which followed this speech Poincaré's majority was overwhelming, 440-6, with the extremes of both right and left abstaining.²⁴ The Radicals, willing to suspend judgment, voted with the majority.

The politics of 1912 were dominated by Poincaré's attempt to fan the fire of nationalism among his compatriots and by the final battle over the passage of the electoral reform bill in the chamber. Historians have concentrated on Poincaré's colorful diplomacy; yet, the debate over *RP* occupied the chamber almost without break from January 23 until July 10, when a final bill was passed by that house. At that time the second round began between the Radical senators and Poincaré,

²¹ *Le Bulletin ARD*, July 9, 1911.

²² *Journal officiel: Débats, Chambre des Députés* (hereafter cited as *JOC*), Jan. 16, 1912, p. 11.

²³ *Ibid.*, pp. 11-12.

²⁴ *Ibid.*: Roll Call 385, Jan. 16, 1912, p. 21.

with Clemenceau and Emile Combes determined to prevent the passage of a reform that would damage the Radicals at the polls. The most significant effect of this legislative hassle was on the one hand to consolidate the coalition of anticlerical conservatives with the clericals and on the other to prevent the cooperation of Radicals and socialists.²⁵

While the chamber was debating *RP*, Poincaré was active in his rôle as minister of foreign affairs, a post rarely assumed by a premier. Through a forceful, outspoken foreign policy and an exaltation of the armed forces, he hoped to create national unity. His first opportunity to apply this new approach was the Franco-Italian incident over the *Carthage* and the *Manouba*, two French freighters seized by the Italian navy on the charge that they were transporting contraband of war to Turkey. Poincaré addressed several vigorous protests to the Italians, and these protests were made public.²⁶ In explaining the incident to the chamber, he took a firm legalistic line.²⁷ The entire chamber applauded his actions. *Le Temps* was overenthusiastic, however, when it concluded that Poincaré had "achieved the unanimity of the representatives of the nation" and that "apaisement est à la mode."²⁸

Perhaps Poincaré originally had not intended to exploit this incident for domestic political purposes, but he handled it in a manner more chauvinistic than diplomatic. His firmness encouraged bellicosity among his countrymen, an attitude he would not condemn. Throughout the year he continued in the same vein. During the period April-July the government vigorously prosecuted the establishment of the protectorate in Morocco, which entailed a full military campaign. Poincaré defended this campaign with enthusiasm in the chamber, emphasizing the civilizing rôle and obligation of France and insisting that the French must never "give the natives the impression of weakness or timidity."²⁹ *Le Temps* interpreted Poincaré as having said that France was by right the "master of North Africa."³⁰ On the occasion of the inauguration of Paul Deschanel as president of the Chamber of Deputies, Poincaré announced his support for the establishment of a new national and, as he said, patriotic holiday in honor of Jeanne

²⁵ See Table 1 for the voting by parliamentary groups on electoral reform. The anticlerical conservatives included the Democratic Left, Republican Union, Progressiste.

²⁶ *Le Temps*, Jan. 20-24, 1912; *L'Intransigeant*, Jan. 18-25, 1912.

²⁷ *JOC*, Jan. 22, 1912, p. 42.

²⁸ Jan. 24, 1912.

²⁹ *JOC*, July 1, 1912, p. 1860.

³⁰ July 2, 1912.

d'Arc.³¹ Clericals and extreme nationalists had been campaigning for such a fête for a number of years.

On March 31 Poincaré with Millerand, as minister of war, and other leading moderates gave nationalistic speeches at a ceremony in memory of Gambetta.³² These speeches were published by the ARD in a booklet entitled *Patriotes avant tout*. Poincaré and his ministers continued propagandizing for nationalism between the end of the summer legislative session and the beginning of Poincaré's widely publicized voyage to Russia.³³

Poincaré, who left from Dunkerque August 5 and returned to Paris August 21, justified this junket as a way to improve communications with the Czar. But other less spectacular means could have been employed, and it is difficult to imagine Monis or Caillaux undertaking a similar mission. Poincaré must have realized the connection between such a gesture and domestic politics. As *Le Bulletin ARD* editorialized: "From the point of view of domestic politics, M. Poincaré's voyage will have the happy result of increasing his prestige, and that of his Ministry, at a time when, more than ever, the republican party is profoundly divided. . . . [This disunion] would cease if all concerned decide to submit to the wisdom, the disinterestedness, the spirit of conciliation . . . of the eminent republicans presently in power. Domestic peace is as necessary as international peace. . . ."³⁴

While Poincaré was focusing public attention on foreign affairs as had no premier before him, Alexandre Millerand, at the ministry of war, followed a consistent policy of enhancing the prestige of the army and strengthening military discipline. The socialist journal *L'Humanité* kept a suspicious eye on Millerand and continually reported his "reforms" in page one editorials with the colorful title "En pleine réaction militaire." *L'Humanité* traced the reaction within the army to the Caillaux ministry's implementation of the conservative plan for the reorganization of the high command.³⁵ This plan entailed the creation of the post of Chef d'état-major général or "gen-

³¹ *JOC*, May 24, 1912, p. 1119. The Senate had passed a bill establishing such a holiday in 1894, and the Chamber had appointed a commission to study the implementation of the Senate bill in 1907. Poincaré succeeded in having another commission appointed in 1912, but the holiday did not become official until 1920, after the victory of the National Bloc (C. J. H. Hayes, *France: A Nation of Patriots* [New York, 1930], p. 101).

³² *Le Bulletin ARD*, April 7, 1912.

³³ *Le Figaro*, July 29, 1912.

³⁴ *Le Bulletin ARD*, Aug. 26, 1912.

³⁵ *L'Humanité*, July 16, 1912.

eralissimo," an officer with command over all of the French army in peace and war. The first man to hold this position was General Joseph Joffre, known to be politically conservative and an advocate of *attaque brusquée*, a theory which presupposed a well-disciplined, thoroughly professional army. Under the influence of the Conseil supérieur de la guerre, Joffre chose General Edouard de Castelnau, labeled "the complete reactionary" by *L'Humanité*, as his administrative secretary.³⁶ During 1912 de Castelnau proceeded to replace the few republican officers in the top echelons of the army's administration with conservatives.³⁷

While this process of reorganization within the army was being completed by de Castelnau, Millerand undertook to increase the army's prestige. His most dramatic act was to allow military reviews to be held in Paris for the first time since 1899. The sound of the military tattoo echoing through Parisian streets brought ecstatic comments from the conservative press.³⁸ Military reviews were held throughout the summer, but the most elaborate was the celebration of the *fête de patriotisme* on July 14.³⁹ In other less colorful ways Millerand tried to dismantle the Radical reforms meant to curb militarism. His first act in office was to end the practice of prefects submitting reports on the political attitudes and activities of military officers.⁴⁰ Since the days of the Combes ministry this practice had been attacked by clericals, who charged the reports were used to prevent the promotion of Catholic officers. Millerand prohibited junior officers from appearing in public out of uniform and restored the right of corporals to deal out punishment to enlisted men.⁴¹ In a measure clearly aimed against officers who belonged to the Freemasons, Millerand issued a circular stating that he intended to enforce the regulation which prohibited officers from belonging to nonmilitary organizations.⁴² Although Millerand justified his measures as necessary to protect French interests, their practical effect was to favor the conservative elements in the army, to encourage chauvinism in the nation, and to discredit the leftist opponents of militarism.

Poincaré's nationalist campaign culminated in a speech he gave at

³⁶ *Ibid.*

³⁷ *Ibid.*, Jan. 13, 1913.

³⁸ Weber, *Nationalist Revival*, pp. 101-2.

³⁹ *L'Humanité*, July 14, 1912.

⁴⁰ *L'Intransigeant*, Feb. 7, 1912.

⁴¹ *L'Humanité*, Jan. 13, 1913.

⁴² *Ibid.*, Aug. 26, 1912.

Nantes several days before the beginning of the fall legislative session. Gone was any concern with internal reforms. The *RP* had been passed in July; no other reform appealed to the Premier. Preoccupied with foreign affairs he expressed a hope for peace in the Balkans and proclaimed his willingness to aid in the search for peace. In words that were to become sacred to nationalists, he called on the French to display "all the pride of a people who do not want a war, but who are not afraid of it. . . ." ⁴³ Reminding his listeners that a nation's moral strength was as important as its material strength, he admonished them to place the "national interest foremost and to relegate particular interests to the second plane." Poincaré, like Briand, was calling for an end of party strife. The editors of *Le Temps* pointed out the connection between Poincaré's nationalist program and Briand's anti-Radical program of *apaisement*:

Thus is clearly seen the connecting link, . . . international prestige and national discipline, foreign policy and domestic policy. In 1905 we tested the imperious rigidity of this link when our diplomacy had to yield less to the external menace than to internal disorder, the work of the Bloc. The country does not want that to happen again. It feels by instinct that a people who lose the notion of a national ideal, or whose public employees are in revolt against the state, or whose public services are disrupted by the insolent demands of particular interests, cannot be the people of whom the Premier spoke. . . . ⁴⁴

Originally, not nationalism but the enactment of an electoral reform detrimental to the Radicals had been the cornerstone of the conservative program. A bill establishing *RP* was passed by the Chamber on July 10. The only significant opposition to this bill came from the center-left. (See Table 1.) The importance of the passage of *RP* was twofold. It allowed the conservatives to be on the winning side in a major legislative contest for the first time in a decade. Clericals and anticlerical conservatives realized that they could defeat the Radicals, with the help, of course, of a few dissident Radicals. On the other hand, the Radicals were forced to recognize that their party's organizational weaknesses and internal divisions had made them vulnerable. The crucial element in the situation was the position of the socialists. As long as electoral reform dominated the Chamber's activities, they were only an accessory—albeit a necessary one—to Poincaré's con-

⁴³ *Le Temps*, Oct. 28, 1912.

⁴⁴ *Ibid.*

TABLE 1
VOTE ON ARTICLE 20 OF THE PROPORTIONAL REPRESENTATION BILL, FEBRUARY 16, 1912*

OFFICIAL GROUPS	Supported RP	Abstained	Opposed RP
Socialist	70	0	3
Republican Socialist	10	3	16
Radical Socialist	45	1	99
Radical Left	34	6	61
Democratic Left	32	2	35
Republican Union	27	0	0
Progressiste	45	0	0
Independents	11	0	7
Liberals	29	0	0
Right	16	2	0
Totals	319	14	221

* JOC, Roll Call 399, Feb. 16, 1912, p. 407.

servative majority. They could not influence the ministry's policies, nor could they oppose them, because this might result in an anti-proportionalist Radical ministry. The passage of *RP* changed this relationship, and the socialists regained their freedom to maneuver. It was not long before they aligned themselves with the Radicals.

By his campaign of *fierté nationale* Poincaré had already begun the countermovement which was to drive the socialists and Radicals into an alliance at the end of 1913. Militarism had intensified anti-militarism which in turn spurred militarists and nationalists to still greater efforts. Eugen Weber, in his study of the nationalist revival in prewar France, has noted that "if the nationalist revival was influential, its scope was very limited."⁴⁵ It is fair to say that it was limited to politicians, journalists, and intellectuals who supported the center-right and right—that is, the parliamentary groups of the Democratic Left, Republican Union, Progressistes, Action libérale, Independents, and Right. Outside of this political and intellectual elite, it is probable that only the regular readers of the conservative press participated in the "revival". The more conservative Radicals wavered between support of and opposition to Poincaré's policy of national pride. When in 1913 a united Radical party offered a clear alternative, all but a few Radicals were willing to vote for measures that Poincaré's supporters could label antipatriotic.

During the summer of 1912, while Millerand was holding military reviews in Paris, the Socialist party and the General Confederation of Labor were conducting an antimilitarist and pacifist campaign.

⁴⁵ Weber, *Nationalist Revival*, pp. 101.

They had begun this campaign during the Agadir crisis and continued it more or less constantly until the autumn of 1913. The SFIO and the leaders of the labor movement took no part in the nationalist revival; rather they demonstrated against it in the streets.⁴⁶

The polarization of French politics which began with these events was completed by the fall of 1913. Three parliamentary confrontations of left and right marked this polarization and testified to the growing strength of the moderate right: the dissolution of the Syndicat des instituteurs in September 1912, the election of Poincaré to the presidency of the Republic in January 1913, and the passage of the Three Years Law on military service in July 1913.

The Syndicat des instituteurs, holding its national congress at Chambéry, had voted on August 17, 1912, to support the *Sou du Soldat*, a society for spreading antimilitarist propaganda among soldiers.⁴⁷ Conservatives, especially clericals who considered the free-thinking school teachers a particular threat to society, were scandalized. Actually the concrete antimilitarist measures which the teachers advocated were quite mild: "subordination of the military to the civilian power; prohibition of the use of troops against strikers; the greatest possible reduction of the time spent [by conscripts] in active service; suppression of military prisons."⁴⁸ To the conservatives the teachers' action was an affront to the nation at a time when all Frenchmen should have united in patriotic support of Poincaré during his Russian visit.⁴⁹ Acting after the premier's return the minister of public instruction declared that the teachers' union must dissolve forthwith. The conservative press was exultant.⁵⁰ They saw the question as one of internal order as much as one of national defense. In an editorial praising the government for the dissolution *Le Temps* avoided any mention of national security and made only passing reference to patriotism. Instead, the editorial expressed the hope that Poincaré's government would be "a Government which will govern, that it not allow itself to be ridiculed by a few functionaries in revolt, that it not allow agitation annoying to the public to continue."⁵¹

⁴⁶ Weber, *Nationalist Revival*; *L'Humanité*, March 8-14, Nov. 16-18 and 25-29, Dec. 17, 1912; Edouard Dolléans, *Histoire du mouvement ouvrier* (Paris, 1953), II, 189-99.

⁴⁷ *Le Temps*, Aug. 18, 1912.

⁴⁸ *La Lanterne*, Aug. 24, 1912.

⁴⁹ *Le Moniteur de l'Oise*, Aug. 25, 1912; *Le Temps*, Sept. 1, 1912; *Le Bulletin ARD*, Sept. 1, 1912.

⁵⁰ *Le Temps*, Sept. 1-8, 1912; *Le Moniteur de l'Oise*, Sept. 1-19, 1912; also see *L'Humanité*, Sept. 19, 1912, for comments on the conservative press.

⁵¹ *Le Temps*, Sept. 8, 1912.

The Radicals did not allow their favorite agents of anticlericalism to be persecuted without complaining. Throughout the controversy *Le Radical* defended the teachers with the argument that they had committed no illegal or antipatriotic act; certainly, antimilitarism was not antipatriotic.⁵² To Radicals the dissolution was nothing less than reactionary. *L'Humanité* took the same position. To the editors of the socialist paper antimilitarism was the height of patriotism; and, when many of the local branches of the Syndicat des instituteurs refused to dissolve, *L'Humanité* printed their defiant manifestoes on its front page.⁵³ Indeed, many of the locals never dissolved, and as early as October 5 *Le Temps* announced that some of those which had voluntarily dissolved in August were being reconstituted. The fate of the teachers' union became a major issue in the fall legislative session.

In the chamber's debate on the dissolution, the arguments expressed earlier in the press were repeated.⁵⁴ The vote which followed this debate (Roll Call 591) indicated that the ministry had the full

TABLE 2
VOTE ON THE DISSOLUTION OF THE SYNDICAT DES INSTITUTEURS, DECEMBER 13, 1912*

OFFICIAL GROUPS	Supported Dissolution	Abstained	Opposed Dissolution
Socialist	0	0	74
Republican Socialist	7	4	22
Radical Socialist	67	31	37
Radical Left	96	5	5
Democratic Left	70	2	0
Republican Union	31	0	0
Progressiste	44	0	0
Independents	17	1	0
Liberals	31	2	0
Right	13	6	0
Totals	376	51	138

* JOC, Roll Call 591, Dec. 13, 1912, p. 3098.

support of the right and center and even of a majority of the Radicals, who were not yet willing to break with Poincaré's centrist majority. The opposition was stronger among the Radical Socialists than among the more moderate Radical Left. (See Table 2.) The real importance of the vote, however, was not the size of Poincaré's majority but that the Chamber was clearly divided into "right" and "left" on the issue.

⁵² *Le Radical*, Aug. 24-Sept. 8, 1912.

⁵³ *L'Humanité*, Sept. 18, 20, 1912.

⁵⁴ For a sampling of this debate see JOC, Nov. 29, 1912, pp. 2375-87; Dec. 6, 1912, pp. 3018-27; and Dec. 13, 1912, pp. 3174-92.

This division was to continue and to become more accentuated until the election of 1914. The events of 1913 finally forced the Radicals, who had remained attached to the center, to move on this vote into a leftist bloc against Poincaré.

The next skirmish in the developing left-right struggle was the presidential election of January 17, 1913. Contrary to all precedent the premier announced that he would seek the presidency of the Republic. Poincaré allowed Agence Havas to make the announcement on December 28, 1912. This was extraordinary because the position was customarily offered to a senior politician by the parliamentary majority. A formal candidacy was unexpected since the office carried prestige but little power. Yet, conservatives had argued since the days of MacMahon that the country needed a strong executive to check the excesses of parliament and to give the country direction. Poincaré had expressed these sentiments as early as 1902 and had often repeated them.⁵⁵

Since early autumn the press had been speculating on possible candidates. The eminent Radical Léon Bourgeois was most frequently mentioned, and Poincaré himself had several times requested Bourgeois to run.⁵⁶ According to the accounts of Briand's biographer, George Suarez, and of Caillaux, Poincaré was pushed into the presidential race by Briand in order that Briand could exercise the real power of national executive as premier.⁵⁷ Suarez, in a convincing account of Briand's activities during the election period, felt called upon to answer rumors current at the time that Briand was acting out of personal ambition.⁵⁸ From all indications, Poincaré was not swept into the presidency on a tide of public opinion. He was indeed popular, but this popularity could not penetrate the "house without windows."⁵⁹

The Radicals opposed Poincaré's candidacy from the first and placed in opposition Jules Pams, minister of agriculture in the cabinets of Monis, Caillaux, and Poincaré. Pams was a respectable mediocrity,

⁵⁵ Wright, *Raymond Poincaré*, pp. 23-25.

⁵⁶ Poincaré, *Au Service de la France*, III, 33.

⁵⁷ Suarez, *Briand: Sa vie—son œuvre* (Paris, 1938), II, 395; Joseph Caillaux, *Mes mémoires* (Paris, 1947), III, 32-37; also cf. E. Beau de Lomenie, *Les Responsabilités des dynasties bourgeoises* (Paris, 1947), II, 44.

⁵⁸ Suarez, *Briand*, II, 395-403.

⁵⁹ This refers to Constantin Melnik and Nathan Leites, *The House Without Windows: France Selects a President* (Evanston, Ill., 1958), in which the authors maintain that the election of the president of the Republic in 1953 was a product of corridor intrigue practiced by men completely isolated from the pressures of public opinion. The president was elected in both the Third and Fourth Republics by a secret vote of all members of the National Assembly.

cast in the mold of past presidents. In a caucus of the left groups held several days before the election, a majority of the left (socialists not included) voted for Pams.⁶⁰ Tradition dictated that the nominee of this caucus should be the only republican candidate, and a delegation of Radicals, headed by Clemenceau, Caillaux, and Emile Combes, visited Poincaré to request that he submit to the decision of the caucus. He refused, arguing that the caucus had represented only a portion of the republican legislators, and its decision, therefore, could not be considered as final.⁶¹

Poincaré's refusal made the anti-Radical nature of his candidacy evident to all. *Le Moniteur de l'Oise* had already predicted that Poincaré's election "will be the knock-out punch for the last frogs from the little ponds [*les petits mares*]"—Briand's term for single-member constituencies—and further remarked that if "M. Poincaré succeeds, all signs point to the use of the *scrutin de liste* with proportional representation . . . in the next election. . . . The new president will personally direct a national policy which . . . can only be honorable and glorious. . . . M. Poincaré will achieve the union of all Frenchmen, so long at war with one another. . . . But that is precisely what will create many enemies for him."⁶²

Thus, the conservative press itself admitted that "national union" could only be achieved over the objections of the Radicals. It would be a national unity in which dissenters would be labeled antipatriots and excluded from the French nation. This formula had already been applied to the railroad workers who had struck "against the nation" and to the teachers' union, whose antimilitarism had been interpreted as antipatriotism. There is evidence that Poincaré accepted the nomination for the presidency with an intention of using that office to continue his campaign of educating the country in the ways of nationalism.⁶³ Analyzing the election, a Radical journalist concluded that "Poincaré has consummated his unity . . . with the groups of the right, a union confirmed by the measures of the Minister of War against the

⁶⁰ This caucus was composed of the deputies and senators of the following groups: Republican Socialist, Radical-Socialist, Radical Left, Democratic Left, Republican Union. The Progressiste senators were allowed to participate but not the Progressiste deputies. Poincaré had wanted these Progressistes included, and, if they had been, he surely would have had a majority. See *La République de l'Oise*, Jan. 2, 1913, and Bonnefous, *Histoire politique*, pp. 318-19.

⁶¹ Poincaré, *Au service de la France*, III, 53.

⁶² Dec. 28, 1912.

⁶³ Wright, *Raymond Poincaré*, p. 30.

republican officers, of the Ministry of Public Instruction against the school teachers. . . ."⁶⁴

Poincaré was elected president of the Republic on January 7, 1913. All observers agree that he owed his election to the support of clericals and reactionaries.⁶⁵ *L'Intransigeant*, a paper associated with the Democratic Left and a supporter of Poincaré, commented, "If M. Poincaré triumphed . . . , it was not with the majority which is called 'republican,' it was with the support of a large number of moderates and even rightists. . . . The triumph of M. Poincaré was the defeat of the Bloc."⁶⁶

Poincaré immediately resigned the premiership. At his suggestion, the outgoing president, Fallières, appointed Briand premier. The most important product of Briand's brief ministry was the proposal that the term of compulsory military service be lengthened to three years, an attack on one of the most sacred of the Radical antimilitarist laws. Historians, in analyzing the positions taken on this issue, have accepted the arguments of the protagonists at face value, as rational reactions to an immediate problem.⁶⁷ The arguments are more intelligible if viewed as tactical maneuvers in the continuing political struggle between the Radicals and the center-right which had begun with Briand's speech in Périgueux. The principal issue was not one of conflicting military theories but of conflicting views of society. The left, insisting on an egalitarian society of free-thinking individuals, argued in favor of fewer professionals, more reserves, and more citizen-soldiers. Conservatives openly expressed admiration for the uniformity, the hierarchy, and the discipline of the professional army. Their aim was to protect social order by discrediting, if not suppressing agitators of the left, and they denounced labor leaders and socialists who opposed the Three Years Law as antipatriots. *L'Echo de Paris* reflected this attitude when it cried to the enemy, "France is speaking, so keep quiet, M. Jaurès."⁶⁸ This exclusive definition of France was used by

⁶⁴ *La République de l'Oise*, Jan. 2, 1913.

⁶⁵ Since this vote was considered a procedural matter, the votes of individual legislators were not recorded in the *Journal officiel*.

⁶⁶ Jan. 19, 1913.

⁶⁷ Bonnefous, *Histoire politique*, pp. 334-49; Chastenet, *Jours inquiets*, pp. 116-19; Harvey Goldberg, *The Life of Jean Jaurès* (Madison, Wis., 1962), pp. 440-43, has a more sophisticated view; Richard Challener, *The French Theory of the Nation in Arms* (New York, 1955), pp. 66-90, places the question in the context of the evolution of military theory from 1870 to 1939; Georges Michon's *La Préparation de la guerre: La Loi de trois ans* (Paris, 1935) is an indictment of Poincaré offering much useful information on the origins and effect of the Three Years Law.

⁶⁸ Goldberg, *Jean Jaurès*, p. 442.

conservatives while Jaurès was drawing crowds as large as 150,000 to rallies protesting the extension of military service.⁶⁹

The most crucial vote on the Three Years Law was not the final one on its passage (taken on July 19, 1913) but the vote on the acceptance of the principle of three years' service. This principle was embodied in Paragraph 4 of Article 18 of the bill. (See Table 3.) Although

TABLE 3
VOTE ON THE PRINCIPLE OF THREE YEARS MILITARY SERVICE, JULY 7, 1913*

OFFICIAL GROUPS	Voted for 3 Years Service	Abstained	Opposed 3 Years Service
Socialist	0	1	73
Republican Socialist	8	2	23
Radical Socialist	40	1	99
Radical Left	73	7	23
Democratic Left	69	2	4
Republican Union	31	0	0
Progressiste	44	0	0
Independents	23	0	1
Liberals	31	0	0
Right	20	0	0
Totals	339	13	223

* JOC, Roll Call 783, July 7, 1913, p. 2492.

some Radicals were in the majority voting for passage of Paragraph 4, only leftists voted against it. This indicated that, while the polarization of the chamber was not complete, it had advanced considerably since the vote of the dissolution of the teachers' union. Because of the Radical votes in favor of the article, it would be possible to argue that for some legislators the division over the Three Years Law was not a left-right polarization but a matter of the national interest which superseded domestic politics. If, however, it can be shown that the Radicals who voted for the Three Years Law were also conservatives in domestic politics, the emphasis on domestic political influences would be validated.

Guttman scale analysis was used to determine which Radicals were conservative and which were "reformist."⁷⁰ This statistical technique allows the classification of legislators into voting blocs according to their votes on any one issue area. In this analysis, the issue of labor reform was used. Studying only the Radical-Socialist and Radical Left

⁶⁹ *L'Humanité*, May 25-26, 1913.

⁷⁰ On Guttman scale analysis cf. Lee F. Anderson *et al.*, *Legislative Roll-Call Analysis* (Evanston, Ill., 1966), chap. 6.

parliamentary groups, one can distinguish eight voting blocs. These blocs are characterized by their voting performance on the following issues: limitation of the length of the workday; Briand's actions in the railroad strike of 1910; rehiring of the railroad workers dismissed during that strike; and improvements in the pension law of 1910. According to their willingness to take positions favorable to labor, I have numbered the voting blocs from one to four. Thus, Voting Bloc I was more willing to vote prolabor than was Voting Bloc II and so forth.

As Table 4 illustrates, conservative Radicals were more likely to

TABLE 4
RADICAL VOTE ON THE THREE YEARS LAW
(By Percentages of Voting Blocs)*

RADICAL-SOCIALIST				RADICAL LEFT			
Voting Bloc	For 3 Years	Abstained	Opposed 3 Years	Voting Bloc	For 3 Years	Abstained	Opposed 3 Years
I	9%	0%	88%	I	55%	0%	45%
II	31	4	62	II	71	0	18
III	31	0	66	III	76	3	21
IV	36	0	58	IV	88	4	4

* Note that some bloc percentages do not total 100 per cent because of absences.

support the Three Years Law than were left-wing Radicals. There is a steady progression in support for the Three Years Law from 9 per cent among Voting Bloc I of the Radical-Socialist group to 88 per cent among Voting Bloc IV of the Radical Left group. This progression supports the contention that the left-right split on Roll Call 783 was closely related to the left-right division over the government's rôle in industrial disputes. It follows that the nationalists of 1913 were the conservatives of 1910-11.

The passage of the Three Years Law was the culmination of the conservative resurgence which had begun in 1910. It also completed the polarization of French politics. The conservative resurgence was heralded by the right as a *renaissance nationale*. Whereas most historians have attributed this nationalist revival to the shock of Agadir, the men involved saw it as developing out of domestic politics. Such was the view of the editor of *L'Intransigeant*, writing several days after the final passage of the military law.

The parliament has submitted, as has the country, to a movement which has lifted it out of its normal rut. This is *the result of five or six years of recovery* [italics added], of a sort of national renaissance

inaugurated by the Briand Ministry, which on the one hand promised appeasement to men of good will and on the other hand suppressed without weakness the illegal railroad strike. The movement was accentuated by the Poincaré Ministry, by the election of [Poincaré] to the Presidency, and, finally, by the Barthou Ministry. . . .⁷¹

Le Moniteur de l'Oise, speaking for conservatives who wanted to push their victory to the extreme, labeled as "traitors" any who opposed the nationalist revival. "An end to the byzantine discussions! Politicians, of no matter what nuance, are betraying their country if they refuse to give their confidence to the government of national defense. *La Patrie* is in danger!"⁷²

The political organization which tried to capitalize on this conservative resurgence was the Alliance républicaine démocratique, now transformed into the Parti républicain démocratique. In its appeal to public opinion the PRD confounded nationalism and antisocialism. The cloak of *apaisement*, which had been designed to bring a conservative coalition to power and to postpone social reforms, was now dropped for a more direct aggressive approach. An editorial in *Le Bulletin ARD* displayed this new confidence. "The republicans will have to choose between two tendencies, between two flags. They will have to decide between the Radical-Socialist Party, which on many points co-operates with the Socialist Party, and the *Parti républicain démocratique*, which aims at rallying all reforming republicans, resolute partisans of social evolution but also anti-collectivists and anti-socialists."⁷³

French conservatives would not have felt confident enough to issue such a challenge in 1909. Since then, however, largely on the basis of Poincaré's nationalist campaign, conservatives of all shades had formed a united front. This unity was substantially, if not entirely, a product of domestic politics. Other trends between 1906 and 1914, such as the rapid growth and increased militancy of organized labor and the geometric progression of socialist voting strength, lend additional weight to an emphasis on domestic politics. It was this threat from the extreme left as well as their desire to displace the Radicals that led moderates like Poincaré to appeal for "national union" on behalf of the social status quo.

⁷¹ July 21, 1913.

⁷² March 7, 1913.

⁷³ April 20, 1913.